

Competitor Brand Audit

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Objectives

Chose three brands similar in business and archetype to the brand chosen for the Rebrand Identity project to audit.

One brand must be the same industry that offers the same product as the chosen brand.

One must be the same archetype as the chosen brand. It has to be the new archetype that the brand is changing to.

The last one can be a choice of one of the first two options.

Boswell Books

Company History

The current owners of Boswell opened the store in 2009 after the old Casanova booksellers closed after 82 years of business. The new owner Daniel Goldin felt moved the store a block away from the original location to be closer to the academics and to start fresh.
Goldin has over 20 years of bookseller experience, so he knew what he wanted for the store. The reason as to why the store isn't a chain business is because he didn't want to run his resources thin and he could be at the store more often to have a more personal connection to the customers. The area is also very historical and draws a lot of people in who love history and learning. There is heavy foot traffic in the area which makes it easy for many people to stop in and look around out of curiosity. The interior is inviting and everything is clearly labeled, making it a very comfortable store to be in.



Mission, Vision and Values

Mission

The store owner states that their mission is “forging relationships with customers, publishers, writers, other retailers, media, nonprofits, everyone”(Schechner).

Vision

Their vision is to bring more events and community connection to the store.

Values

The company values history and strong customer connections.





Visual Identity Analysis

Logo Design:

The main logo is an old ink drawing from the original bookstore's owners. The design looks like its from an old history book. The two "B's" design is separate from the main image and also includes a frog illustration that represents the B.

Color Palette:

The only color i've seen used for the logo is black. The bookstore itself has many warm toned colors.

Typography:

The main typeface is simple and is there to be read easily. The two "B's" are decorative and patterned.

Imagery:

The latest logo of the frog gives the store a magical and fictional feel. The man holding the book and the simple letters only made it feel like it catered to non-fictional genres, but this new one is much more interesting.

Target Audience

The main target audience for this business are people who enjoy learning and consuming physical media. The bookstore location is located in a place with heavy foot traffic, so it also caters to those who like exploring new stores and topics. The multiple author events also cater to avid book readers and the community of people who support that author.

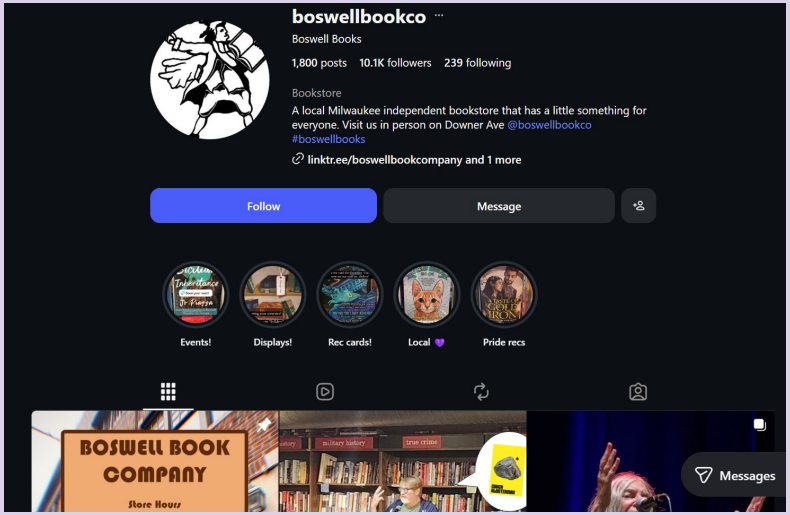
The second demographic of people are students and other academics. Due to its close location to the campus and student living, the store is easily accessible to people who need books for a class.

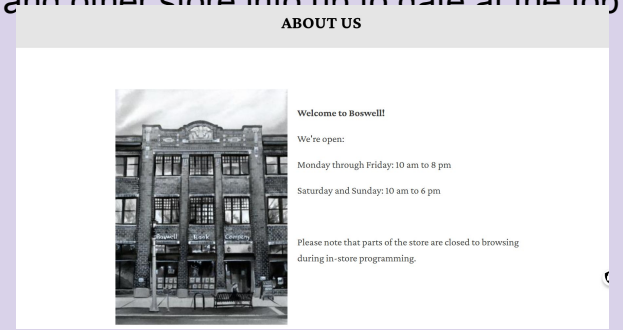


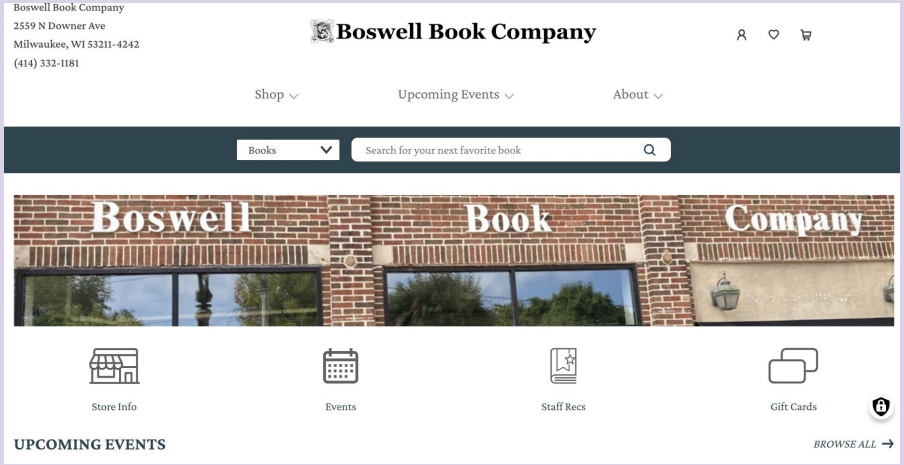
Digital Presence Evaluation

Their website could have more information on the store itself. There are decades of history behind the store and there is only a few sentences of information on their website. However, it is easy to navigate and has a simple and clean layout.

Their Instagram page is well updated and the posts have good images. Their posts consist of new book releases, upcoming in-store events, and author visits. They are constantly promoting authors and recommendations. Their facebook page consists of the same posts from their other social media. They have all of their contact and other store info up to date at the top of the page.

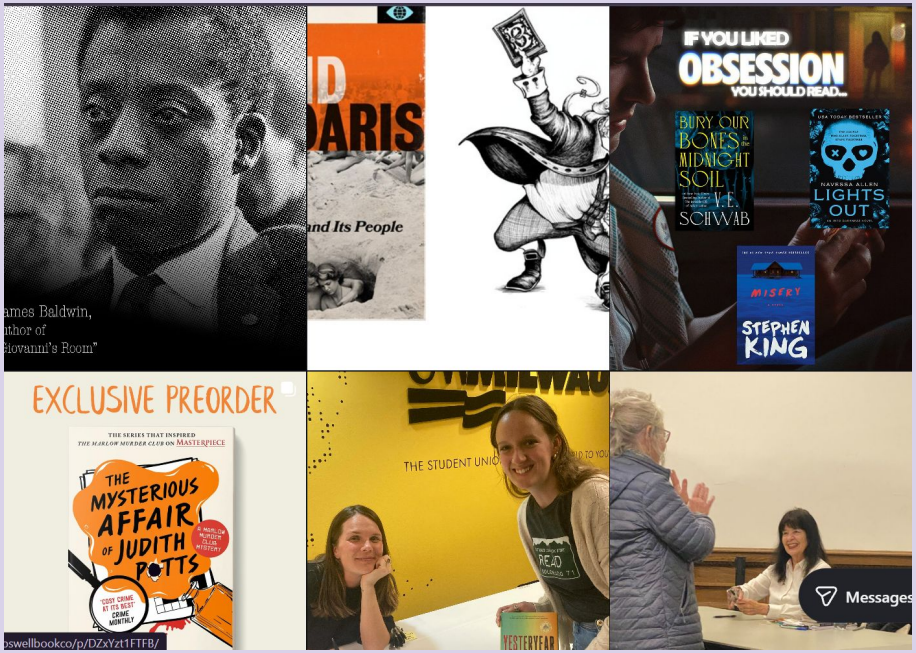






Brand Message and Content Analysis

Their posts highlight their strong connection to authors and community events. They show images and videos of author meets and many book recommendations.



Product/Service Evaluation

Boswell sells books, puzzles, and a variety of merchandise. Many people stated in their reviews that the store has a great selection of items and is in a great community location. The pricing isn't the lowest compared to other stores, but the store environment is more inviting and so is the surrounding community. This store is constantly having events and has personal recommendations all across the shelves.

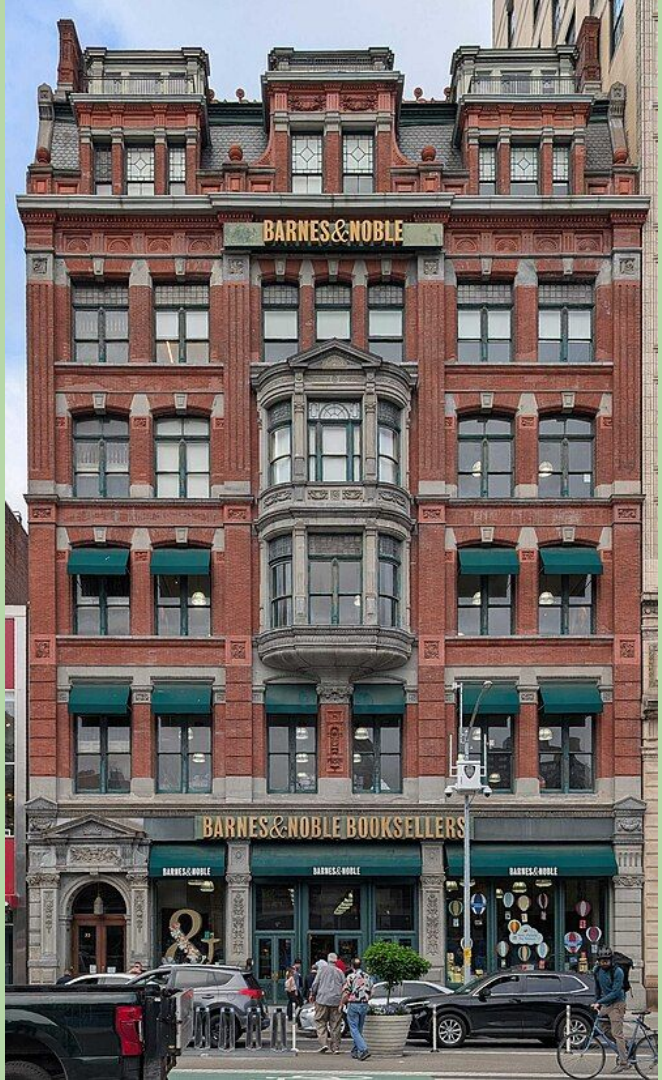
Opportunities and Threats

This store has very few issues with business and presence. The in store community is vibrant and constantly busy. However, one thing that they could expand more on, is their online presence. Their website is simple, but lacks more information on the store itself. There are also very few interviews about the store online.

Barnes and Noble

Company History

The store name started in 1873 by Charles M. Barnes. His son William Barnes created Barnes and Noble in New York with G. Clifford Noble in 1917. It was very successful and sold to millions of people. In 1971 Leonard Riggio bought the name and expanded it even further, thus turning it into the world's largest bookstore. As it grew the company owner made every decision possible to add more to the store and make more stores.



Mission, Vision and Values

The brand's stated mission is "To operate the best omni-channel specialty retail business in America, helping both our customers and booksellers reach their aspirations, while being a credit to the communities we serve"(Astrogrowth).

Their vision is to be more than a typical bookstore by having more options besides books and making it easier to purchase items.

The four values respect, empathy, responsibility, and integrity mean that they strive to make their stores comfortable and have a wide variety of books or other items to choose from.



Visual Identity Analysis

Logo Design:

A simple text only design. No mascot or imagery is used for the logo.

Color Palette:

Earthy colors that look sophisticated and calming.

Typography:

Easy to read typeface with a slight difference for the & symbol to add a slight visual change. The “&” has a more historical look to it to make it feel historical.

Imagery:

There are no images in the main design, but the layout is very recognizable and usually displayed rather large on the buildings they are in.

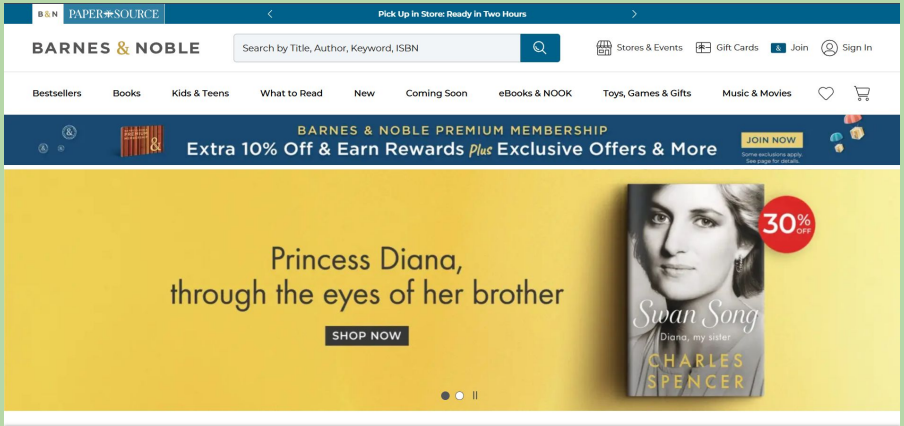
Target Audience

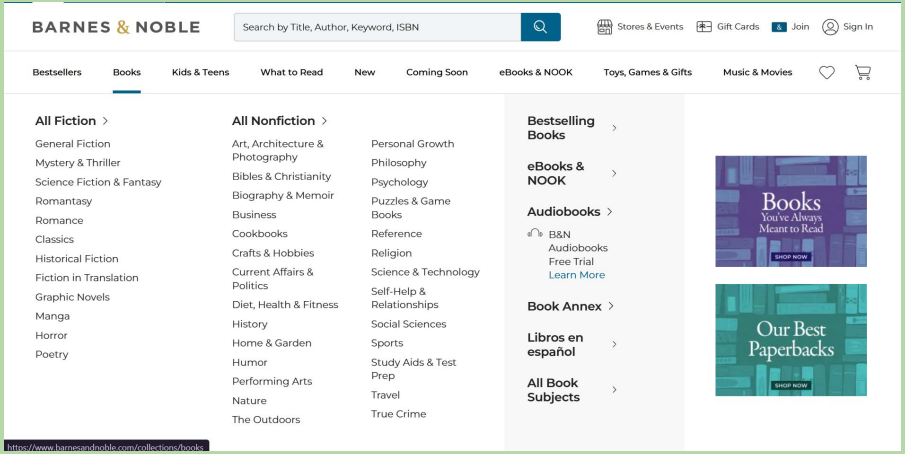
Anyone who wants to expand their knowledge on a topic or enjoy a good story. People who want a store they know will have what they are looking for.



Digital Presence Evaluation

The website is easy to navigate and is very clean. It's not too overwhelming despite having many recommended books on the homepage. Their instagram page updates everyday with authors speaking on their books or upcoming events in stores. They have all their information linked and easy to find in their bio and highlights. Their facebook is the same way with videos being consistently uploaded to make sure all their platforms are constantly updated.







Brand Message and Content Analysis

The main message I've noticed in their posts is keeping people interested in reading and community connections. They jump straight to the point and have an upbeat tone in every video showing what's new.



Product/Service Evaluation

They sell a variety of physical media from books to puzzles. On Barnes & Noble's website they state that pricing is low for new readers and they charge more if there is a higher demand. They have many different sales available. Some sales are better for those who buy online and others have the membership program which offers a discount on most items and rewards. Many customers like the clean and nicely displayed shelves and cafe that is usually attached to the stores.

Opportunities and Threats

Many people have noticed that their prices are higher than most other places. They do have sales often but many people can find the book they are looking for at another store or online second hand. They could expand on a second hand book market and sell slightly damaged/used books for a lower price.

Godiva

Company History

The store name started in 1873 by Charles M. Barnes. His son William Barnes created Barnes and Noble in New York with G. Clifford Noble in 1917. It was very successful and sold to millions of people. In 1971 Leonard Riggio bought the name and expanded it even further, thus turning it into the world's largest bookstore. As it grew the company owner made every decision possible to add more to the store and make more stores.



Mission, Vision and Values

Mission

“Our mission is to bring the ultimate chocolate experience to the world by blending craftsmanship, quality, and creativity in every bite” (Godiva, About).

Vision

To make artisanal luxury chocolate that shows their belgium roots and create a unique experience to all who enjoy their product.

Values

Their values include their heritage, innovation, and good customer experiences. They strive to create an emotional and connecting experience to the brand's specially crafted chocolate.



Visual Identity Analysis

Logo Design:

Has the image above the brand name and smaller as to not distract people from reading the name because of its intricate design.

Color Palette:

Mainly uses a metallic gold for their labeling, but also uses brown and black. The colors represent luxury and comfort.

Typography:

The typeface for the brand name is sans serif but still has slight curves in the lettering to show some elegance. The name often has the word Chocolatier below it in an italicized script-like font.

Imagery:

Shows an image of a woman riding a horse. This is Lady Godiva whom the brand was named after. The lines are smooth and elegant. Uses the same golden brown colors for many packaging designs. There is also red mixed into many designs to bring forth contrast and that archetype of being “The Lover”

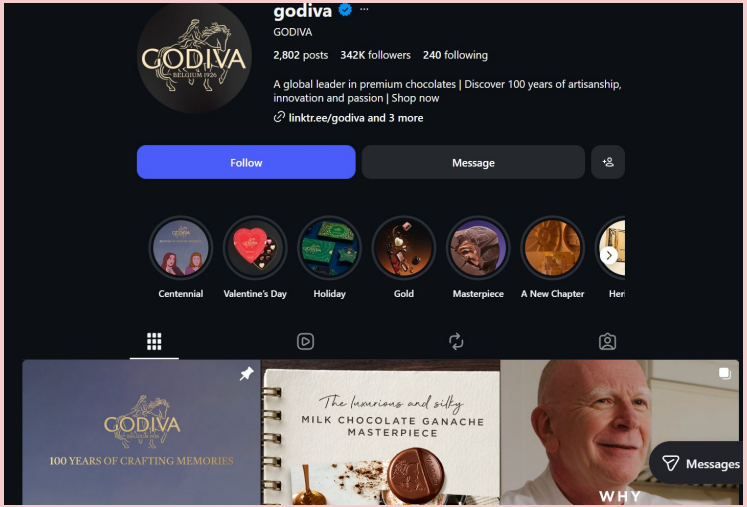
Target Audience

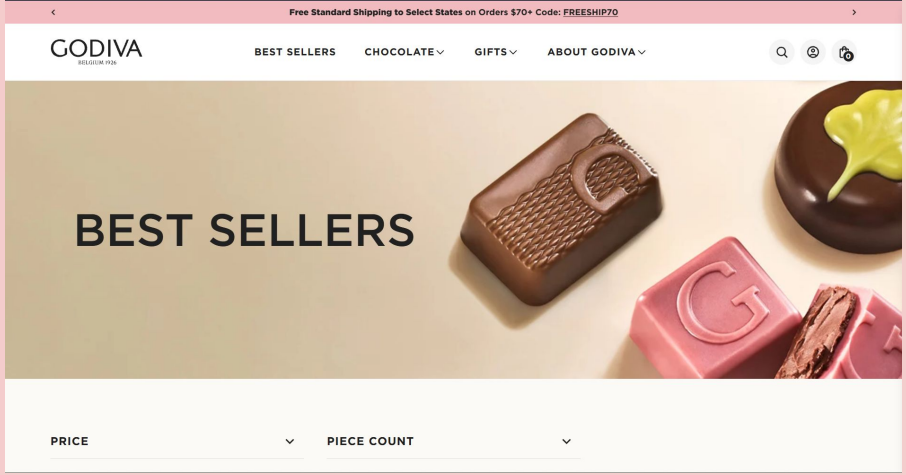
Anyone who appreciates luxury chocolate and sustainability.

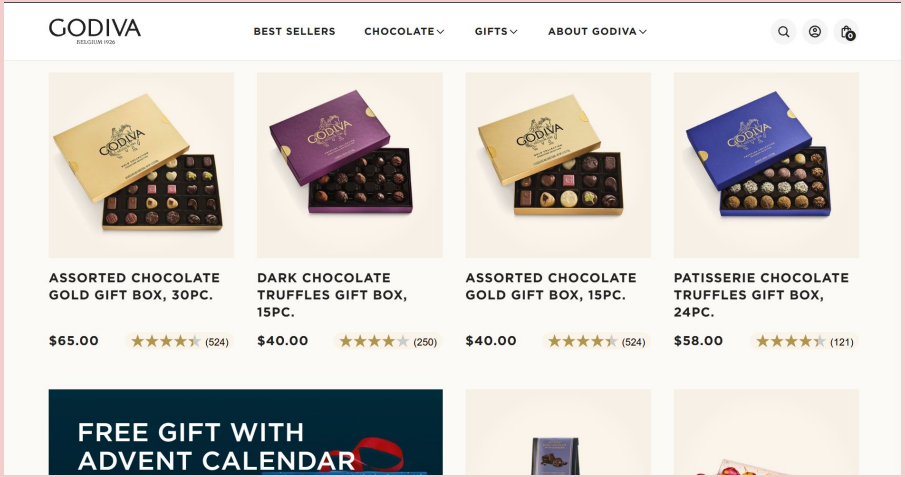


Digital Presence Evaluation

Their website is easy to navigate and has the same color scheme as their packaging. The reviews are displayed on the chocolate that they sell online. Their instagram contains well done photography of their chocolate and videos of the chocolatiers answering questions about the chocolate. Their facebook has the same format and is just as updated as their instagram.







Brand Messaging and Content Analysis

Many advertisements on their social media tells a story that connects the reader to a personal moment or emotional time.

Product Service Evaluation

This brand offers a wide variety of luxury handcrafted chocolate. The cost of having good quality and sustainably made chocolate can be expensive, but the taste is worth it. To make people feel like the price is worth the product, they cater to the emotions of viewers. Many people mentioned on their online reviews that the chocolate is delicious and there is a wide variety to choose from. However, there were many people giving low star reviews due to the troubles with online orders and cost of the chocolate.

Opportunities and Threats

The cost and lack of in person stores is a large threat to this company's existence. Many people stated in the reviews that there used to be more locations and the customer service has become less welcoming.



Half Priced Books

Company History

Ken Gjemre and Pat Anderson decided to purchase an old laundry mat in Texas and turn it into “Half Priced Books” in 1972. Gjemre grew up on a farm that reused equipment and was very hesitant to throw things away.



Mission, Vision and Values

Mission

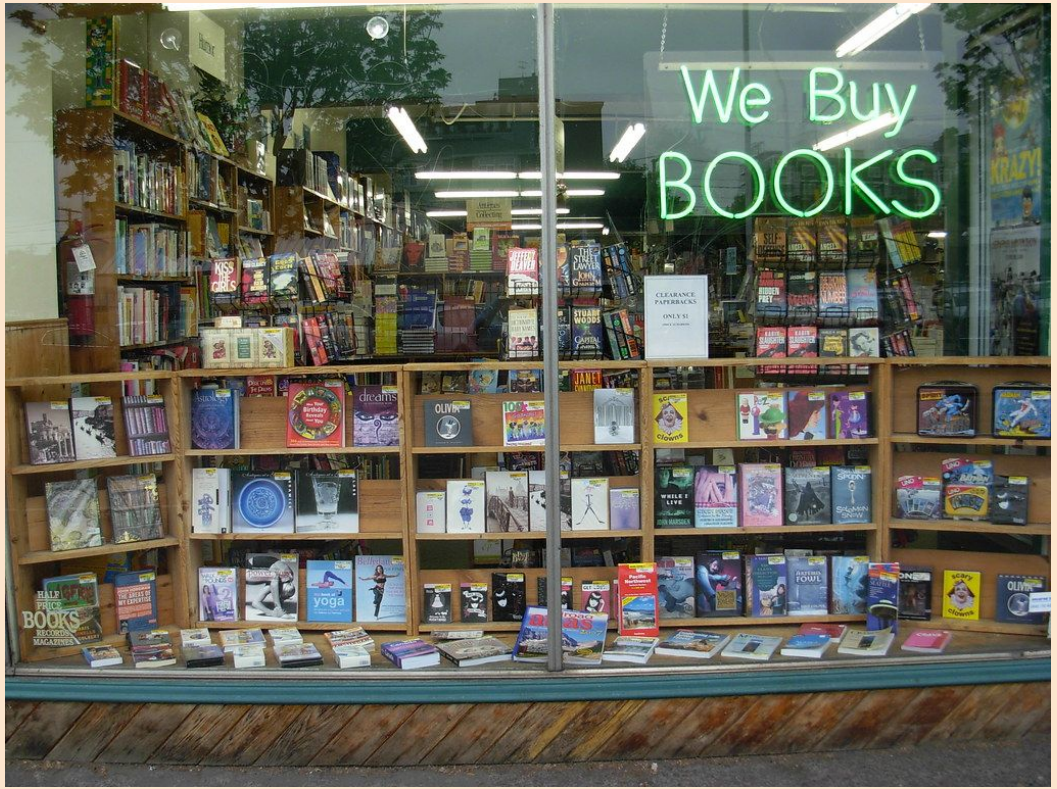
Their mission is to have affordable books available to everyone and to promote sustainability.

Vision

To continue making their buying/selling experience easier and more accessible.

Values

Partnering with charities and literacy programs, and promoting greener business practices.



Visual Identity Analysis

Logo Design:

The logo is neatly aligned text with no imagery..

Color Palette:

The logo is either bright red on a white background or white on a red background. Many sale signs are bright contrasting colors meant to grab people's attention and this makes sense for what the store sells.

Typography:

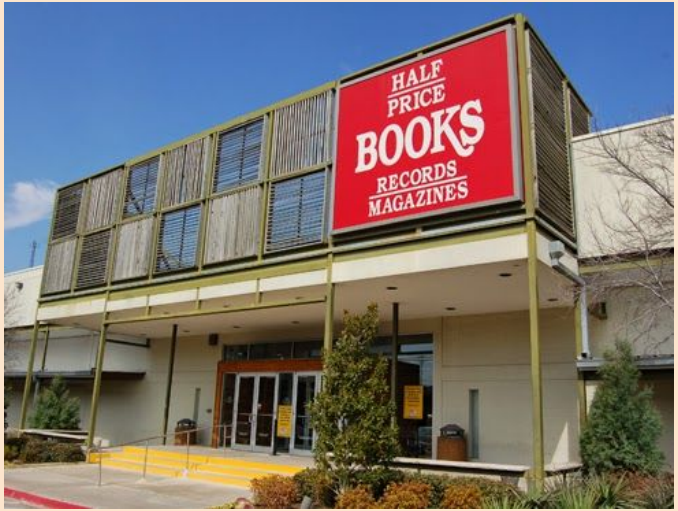
The type uses a Serif font and slight alterations on the serifs on the word Books to bring a little whimsy into the stern looking typeface.

Imagery:

There is only a line separating the Half and Priced words to bring forth the idea of prices being very low at the store. Much like a sale sign, the text is the main part of the design.The stores and online site uses the same simple red and white colors with very little intricate design. Many people just want to find the book they are looking for without being distracted or overwhelmed by an overdesigned store or user experience.

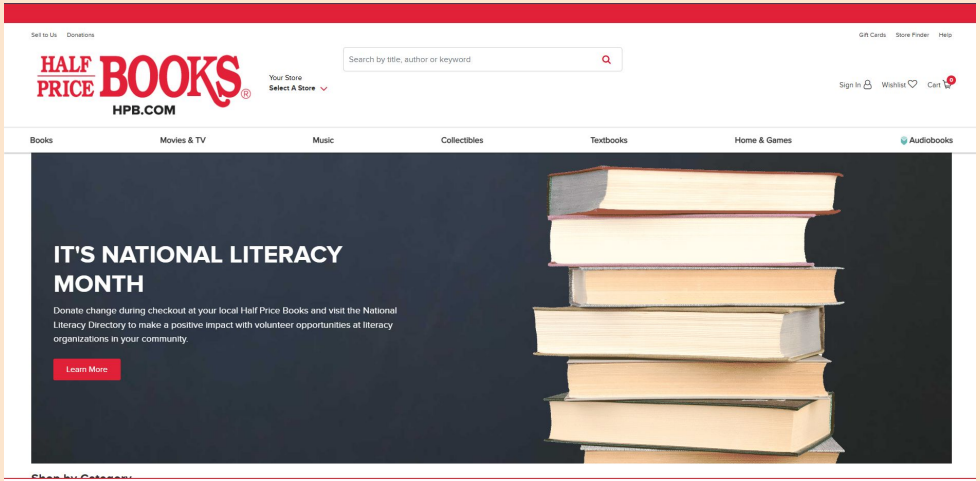
Target Audience

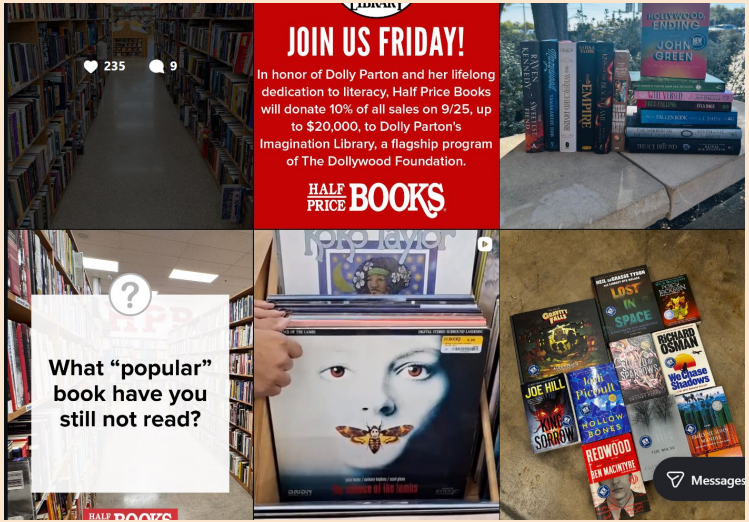
Those who want to buy books sustainably and enjoy collecting old or hard to find prints of certain media.

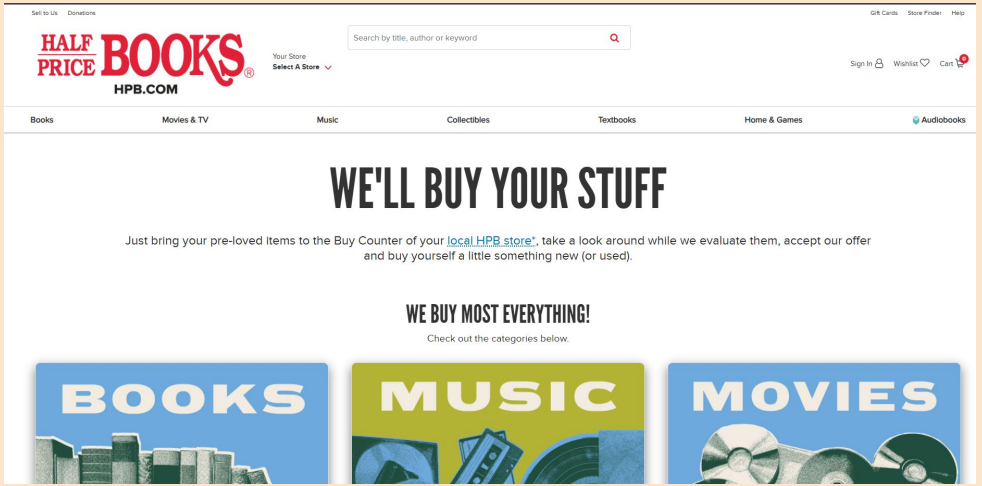


Digital Presence Evaluation

Half Priced Book's website is very clean and spaced out to make it easier to understand. Everything is organized and easy to search for. Their online presence is intended to feel personal and fun. They ask book related questions to have customer interactions and have a bookworm mascot to bring fun and whimsy into their advertisements.







Brand Messaging and Content Analysis

They use many photos taken from inside their stores to show people how many books they have available. They like to post book related questions on their social media to bring more customer interactions.

Product Service Evaluation

They focus on selling used, low-price books and other printed media. They charge no more than half of the original price of the book to make them more accessible to people. Many reviews say that the store has a good layout and that there is a wide selection of records, collectables, and books. However, there were mixed reviews for the pricing. Many people said that a lot of books were close or the same price as a new one and others say that there are many good deals.

Opportunities and Threats

This book store is mostly used books and has a small percentage of new releases. Many people would have to go to a larger chain store to find what they are looking for. What they could do is keep up to date on which new releases are in high demand at the time and then designate a section to those books.



Summary

I found the Godiva brand the most interesting because it has the archetype that I am switching my brand to. I noticed the colors are slightly similar to the ones in most bookstores and I was able to get more ideas on how to portray this archetype onto my brand. Based on my findings, I have a better idea of what direction I want to go with the brand's new archetype. I feel the Godiva brand audit was most helpful with that for understanding the advertising and design styles that go with that archetype. Something that surprised me that I never noticed before was how similar the color pallets are of bookstores. Colors play an important role in how people feel about a brand.

Citations

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